Green Sea Turtles Are Making a Comeback

From: Smithsonian Science-Nature Mined: 2026-10-26 3 min read

On a quiet beach at night, a green sea turtle climbs out of the sea to lay her eggs. On **Aldabra**, a far-off island group 400 miles off Africa's east coast, this sight is much more common than it was 50 years ago.

People once hunted green turtles for meat, leather, and eggs. By the 1960s, only 2,000 to 3,000 nests were found on **Aldabra** each year. A hunting ban in 1968 gave the turtles safety, and researchers have watched their nests for more than 50 years.

The wait was long because green turtles do not start **breeding** until they are 25 to 35 years old. But the turtles came back. In 2019, workers counted more than 15,000 groups of eggs, a 173 percent rise since 1980.

In October 2025, the International Union for **Conservation** of Nature moved green turtles from **endangered** to least concern. Still, the recovery is not even. One small group in the south-central Pacific is in serious trouble, and environmental economist Adam Pritchard says the work is definitely not done.

Word Treasure

Aldabra -- A far-off group of islands where green sea turtles nest.

endangered -- At serious risk of dying out completely.

Conservation -- Protecting animals, plants, and nature so they can survive.

breeding -- Producing babies, in this case turtle eggs that hatch into young turtles.

Background you need

Sea turtles are reptiles that live in the ocean and come ashore on beaches to lay their eggs.

Hunting once reduced their numbers, so rules that ban hunting give turtles a safe place to recover.

Because turtles take many years to grow old enough to breed, a comeback can take a very long time.

Break it down

WHO: Green sea turtles, researchers who watch their nests, and environmental economist Adam Pritchard.

WHAT: Green sea turtles nesting on Aldabra in much greater numbers than 50 years ago.

WHERE: Aldabra, a far-off island group off Africa's east coast, and one small group in the south-central Pacific.

WHY: A hunting ban gave the turtles safety, and researchers have watched their nests for more than 50 years.

Why it matters

Protecting animals can help them come back, so the beaches and oceans you visit one day may still have sea turtles.

Test what you remember

1. Where do the green sea turtles in this story nest?

- (A) On beaches in Iowa
- (B) On a farm
- (C) In a zoo
- (D) On Aldabra, an island group off Africa's east coast

2. What did people once hunt green turtles for?

- (A) Meat, leather, and eggs
- (B) Their shells for jewelry only
- (C) Their bones for tools
- (D) Sport

3. When did the hunting ban on Aldabra begin?

- (A) 2025
- (B) 2019
- (C) 1968
- (D) 1980

4. Why did the turtle recovery take so long?

- (A) Green turtles do not start breeding until they are 25 to 35 years old
- (B) The beaches were closed
- (C) Turtles sleep all winter
- (D) Researchers stopped watching

5. How many groups of eggs were counted in 2019?

- (A) More than 15,000
- (B) 2,000 to 3,000
- (C) About 100
- (D) Exactly 50

6. What happened to green turtles in October 2025?

- (A) They became extinct
- (B) They were moved to a zoo
- (C) They stopped laying eggs
- (D) They were moved from endangered to least concern

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Adam Pritchard: He says the work is definitely not done.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):